Navigating the UALR Dissertation Process

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Some Common Questions about the Dissertation Process

- **How long does it take to write a dissertation?** It varies but on average it takes 12 to 18 months, depending on the timeline to collect your research data.
- **How many hours of work are involved with writing a dissertation?** Again, it varies but a rough time estimate is you can expect to spend at least 2000 hours.
- **How many pages should a dissertation be?** Most dissertations are in the 100 to 200 page range (one study found the min – 21 pages, max – 2002 pages, mean 177 pages, medium – 161 pages).
- **What format should I use for the dissertation?** See the UA Little Rock Graduate School Thesis and Dissertation Guidelines - https://ualr.edu/gradschool/home/thesis-and-dissertation-information/

Where do I start?

- **Attributes of a Good Research Question**
  - Answering your question should make a contribution to your discipline (i.e., novel, advancement).
  - Answering your question should be of interest to others (i.e., impact, usage).
  - Answering your question should be feasible (i.e., you have or can acquire the skills, knowledge, and resources you need).

- **Process for Finding Your Research Question**
  - Start broad, scanning your areas of interest (See Resources on next page).
  - Check out what UA Little Rock Research Active Faculty are doing.
  - Study what other researchers are doing (literature review)
  - As you get to know your area better, you can better identify potential question(s)/challenge(s).

Advice for Finding Good Dissertation Questions

- **Identify a Good Problem**
  - What are your Faculty / Employers working on?
  - What are the hot topics at conferences?
  - Check Challenge/Grant sites like grants.gov and www.wazokucrowd.com/
  - Look for problems/issues in the media/press
- **Other opportunities for discovery**
  - New sources of data
  - Emerging technologies
  - Check for cross-over approaches from other fields/disciplines

- **Build your Background**
  - Books
  - Journal Review Articles
  - Conference Proceedings
  - ProQuest Dissertations
  - Internet/Web Resources
  - Library/Database Sources
  - Training/Tutorials
- **Literature Review Goals**
  - What are other people working on in this area?
  - How they are doing it (e.g., what data/evidence are they collecting, what analysis methods are they using, what results are they finding, etc.)?

Developing Your Research Proposal

- **Form a CIS PhD Committee**
  - Identify a Research Advisor (Dissertation Chair)
  - Identify other Individuals who can provide expertise to your research (minimum of 3 other people).
  - Chair and at least 1 other member must have Full Graduate Status and be Faculty in CPSC or IFSC.
  - 1 member must have Full Graduate Status at UALR (i.e., any department).
  - Remaining members can be anyone holding graduate faculty status at UALR including those with Affiliate Graduate Faculty Status

- **Research Proposal Steps**
  1. Student completes their qualifying exam with 3 faculty, demonstrating they have sufficient background to begin the dissertation process.
  2. Student works with their Research Advisor to write up their initial proposal.
     a. Introduction to Topic
     b. Problem/Objectives
     c. Literature Review
     d. Research Design
     e. Timeline for Completion
  3. Student works with their Advisor and Committee to write and defend the research proposal.

Conducting Your Research

- IRB – Important to verify if there are any human subject issues.
- Collect Your Data
  - What evidence will you need to collect to answer your research questions?
- Analyze Your Data
  - What type of analysis techniques will you need?
  - What type of analysis tools will you need?
  - What type of training will you need?
- Communicate, Communicate with your Advisor/Committee
- Possible Analysis Questions
  - Descriptive Analysis – What happened (patterns, anomalies, exploration)?
  - Diagnostic Analysis – Why did it happen (hypothesis testing, causal analysis)?
  - Predictive Analysis – What is likely to happen (statistics, data mining)?
  - Prescriptive Analysis – What action should happen or can we make happen? (machine learning, artificial intelligence)?
  - Any Other Questions?
- Choose the Research / Study Design that will support your dissertation objectives.

Tips for Writing Your Dissertation

1. Make a Schedule. Set deadlines.
2. Just Start Writing. Keep a journal of your research progress and activities.
3. The First Draft is Not the Final Draft. Read and edit.
4. Be Flexible. Strive for good quality, not perfection.
5. Write the Introduction and Abstract Last
6. Move Around (i.e., if you get stuck, move to another section and come back later)
7. Get Feedback Early. Talk about your ideas with others.
8. Take Care of Your Health
9. Give Yourself Breaks
10. Use a Reference Manager to keep track of your citations.

Dissertation Format

- **Main Sections**
  - Abstract (Write Last)
  - Introduction (Write Last)
  - Review of Literature To Date and How Your Work Fits In
  - Design and Methodology for how you collected your evidence (e.g., data) to investigate your research question(s)
  - Analysis and Discussion for the answers you found to your research question(s)
  - Conclusions and areas for future research

- Look for conference opportunities to get feedback (and publication) of your work
- https://scientific-publishing.webshop.elsevier.com/research-process/how-to-choose-a-journal-to-submit-an-article/
- https://www.phdstudies.com/article/How-to-Get-Published-in-an-Academic-Journal/

Defending Your Final Dissertation

1. Check the calendar and choose the semester that you expect to fully finish so you know when to apply for Graduation.
2. Schedule Dissertation Defense – Be sure to give your committee members time (7 to 10 days) to review your thesis draft.
3. Day/Time/Place of Dissertation Defense should be published so guests can attend.
4. Submit one original copy of defended dissertation for review to the UALR Graduate School (Dec 1 for Fall, May 1 for Spring, Aug 1 for Summer).
5. Check that Your Program's Coordinator has submitted Appointment/Decision of Supervisory Committee.
6. After all requested format and committee revisions have been made, upload Dissertation to ProQuest

What to Expect During the Defense

Dissertation Defenses typically take 1.5 to 2 hours

1. ~45 minutes to present the major milestones of your dissertation.
2. ~15 minutes to take questions/comments from the Public Audience. Guests will then be dismissed.
3. ~10 to 20 minutes to take questions/comments from your Dissertation Committee.
4. ~10 to 20 minutes for your Dissertation Committee to deliberate. During this deliberation, you will leave the room. You will be called back when your Committee is ready to render their decision.
5. ~10 to 20 minutes to hear the decision of the Dissertation Committee and to find out any edits/changes/additional work they would like to see in the final dissertation draft.

Applying for Graduation

- **Graduation Requirements**
  - Successful completion of an approved program of study with a minimum GPA of 3.0
  - Successful completion of the candidacy examinations
  - Successful completion of the dissertation proposal and oral defense
  - Successful completion of the dissertation and oral defense

- **PhD Curriculum**
  - Minimum of 75 credit hours beyond the baccalaureate degree including a minimum of 33 hours of course-work from 5000 (limit 4) and 7000 level courses, and a minimum of 42 credit hours of 9000-level doctoral dissertation.
  - Apply for graduation through boss.ualr.edu
  - Attend Ceremony and be hooded by your Research Advisor!

Advice on Finding a Job

- Publish/Present your results as you work on your thesis - https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/research/academic-program/give-great-research-talk/.
- Important to network, build relationships, and contacts.
- Think about all your career options – Academic, Industry, Government, Consulting, etc.
- Find the job sites, listservs, conferences, industry groups, companies, organizations, etc. where jobs are advertised in your area.
- Think about your career from Day 1. Remember too that a job search takes time (seeking, applying, interviewing, hiring).
- Work on your resume (cv), interviewing, job talk skills.
- It is okay to apply to multiple positions at a time.
- It is okay not to accept your first offer.
- It is okay to research salary data and negotiate (https://cra.org/resources/taulbee-survey/).

Any Questions?

Check out our Graduate Student Advising Materials available from https://blackboard.ualr.edu/ultra/organizations/_122523_1/cl/outline.

Note: You can just go our https://ualr.edu/informationscience/ website and find the link (at the bottom) of our navigation pane.